Why Doesn’t This Book Use Import Maps?



Since the first version of this book was released, the default set of tools that Rails offers for a new application has changed. More than once. The new default is to use import maps and a standalone command line for Tailwind CSS, allowing for a Rails app that does not require Node.js or the Node Package Manager (NPM).

However, for most of this book, we do not use import maps (you can see samples of how they work in Appendix 1, *Framework Swap*. There’s a philosophical reason and a practical reason. The philosophical reason is that it’s not clear to me what is the upper bound of how complex an app can get using import maps, and I’ve decided to err on the side of caution. (That said, the Hotwire flagship app Hey.com uses import maps.)

The practical reason is that the book’s code already relies on React’s JSX and TypeScript, both of which require the kind of compilation step that import maps are supposed to get rid of. Because Rails 7 provides a whole other set of great new tools for bundling projects that require compilation steps, I decided to present that, rather than limit the scope of the book only to tools supported by import maps.